Advocacy: Facilitator Guide

Business Academy Group Learning · Advocacy · September 2027

Session at a glance

In 60 minutes, providers learn how to tell their program's story with real numbers, share it with decision-makers, and stay connected to advocacy efforts. As the final session, it also celebrates the year and reminds providers about the post-assessment.

Item	Detail
Month	September 2027
Audience	Business Academy providers, center-based and home-based
Length	60 minutes
Format	[In person / virtual]
Materials	Sample one-page program story, local and state officials contact list, celebration supplies, certificates, printed Tips and Tricks sheet and Provider Handout
Ask providers to bring	Their Budgeting Tool and one story about a family their program has helped

Learning goals

By the end, each provider can:

1. Explain why provider voices matter to child care policy.
2. Write a short program story using their own numbers.
3. Identify their local and state officials and how to reach them.
4. Choose one advocacy action to take in the next month.

Agenda

Time	Segment
0:00 – 0:05	Welcome and opener: "What do you wish decision-makers knew?"
0:05 – 0:15	Why advocacy matters: your story plus your numbers
0:15 – 0:30	Telling your story, knowing your officials, and staying connected
0:30 – 0:45	Activity: Write your one-page program story
0:45 – 0:55	Implementation: your 30-day plan and one commitment
0:55 – 1:00	Takeaways and wrap-up

Why advocacy matters

Opener, "What do you wish decision-makers knew?": Ask providers to finish the sentence "I wish decision-makers knew…" on a sticky note. Read several aloud; they often become the heart of each provider's story.

Talking points:

- **Providers are experts.** Decision-makers need to hear from the people who run child care every day.
- **Your numbers are powerful.** A year with the Budgeting Tool means you can show the real cost of care.
- **Stories make numbers stick.** One family's experience brings the data to life.
- **Advocacy can be small.** An email, a visit, or a public comment all count.
- **You don't have to do it alone.** Coalitions and your Ready Region can help amplify your voice.

Core content: making your voice count

Build your program story

Part	Example
Who you are	"I run a family child care home serving 8 children in [county]."
Who you serve	"Most of my families work in health care and retail."
Your numbers	"It costs me $___ per child to provide care, and families pay $___."
A real story	One family your program helped (with permission, and no private details)
The challenge	What makes it hard to stay open or pay teachers
Your ask	One clear thing you want the decision-maker to know or do

Ways to take action

- **Contact officials.** Email or call your local and state representatives with your story.
- **Invite a visit.** Ask an official to tour your program.
- **Speak locally.** Share your story at a board of supervisors or city council meeting.
- **Join a coalition.** Connect with statewide early childhood advocacy groups and your Ready Region.
- **Share with families.** Help parents understand the real cost of care and how to speak up.

Celebrate the year

Close the pilot by celebrating each provider's progress. Invite providers to share one business practice they changed this year, hand out certificates, and remind everyone about the post-assessment deadline.

Remind providers to protect family privacy: get permission before sharing any family story, and leave out names and identifying details.

Implementation: your 30-day plan

Each provider leaves with one commitment and a 4-week plan; the Business Specialist checks progress at the next coaching session. Progress here also counts toward the pilot goal of at least one new or improved business practice per provider.

Week	Action	Done when
Week 1	Finish your one-page program story with your own numbers.	Story is written
Week 2	Look up your local and state officials and their contact information.	Contacts are listed
Week 3	Take one action: send your story, invite a visit, or attend a meeting.	One action is taken
Week 4	Complete the post-assessment and share your story with your Business Specialist.	Post-assessment is done

Tie-in to coaching

At the next individual coaching session, the Business Specialist will:

- ☐ Review the program story and the numbers in it
- ☐ Talk through the advocacy action and any response
- ☐ Confirm the post-assessment is complete and plan next steps beyond the pilot
- ☐ Note any business practice change in the provider's progress record

Commitment card

Have providers fill this in before they leave and keep a copy:

- What I wish decision-makers knew: _____
- My cost per child to share: _____
- The official I will contact: _____
- My one advocacy action: _____

Key takeaways

Close the session by reading these aloud; they also appear on the Provider Handout.

1. **You are the expert.** Your daily experience is what decision-makers need to hear.
2. **Use your numbers.** Your Budgeting Tool shows the real cost of care.
3. **Tell a real story.** One family's experience makes the numbers matter.
4. **Make one clear ask.** Decision-makers act on specific requests.
5. **Keep going together.** Stay connected with your peers and your Ready Region.

Activities and discussion

Activity: Write your one-page program story (15 minutes)

Using the story table, providers draft their one-page story, pulling cost per child and other numbers from their Budgeting Tool. Pairs read each other's stories and suggest one way to make the ask clearer. Volunteers read theirs aloud.

Discussion questions

- What do you wish more people understood about running child care?
- Have you ever contacted an elected official? What happened?
- Which number from your budget surprised you most this year?
- How could providers in our region speak up together?

Peer Connections prompt (September)

"Celebrate: one business practice I changed this year." Each provider shares one practice they started or improved during the pilot and what difference it made. Close with appreciation and plans to stay connected.

Handouts for this session

Walk through the **Advocacy Tips and Tricks** sheet during the content segment, and give out the **Advocacy Provider Handout** at the end.